

Corals and coral reefs

Corals are close relatives of sea anemones, and have the same tubular body form, called a polyp, with a crown of tentacles surrounding a central mouth. But unlike anemones, many corals form colonies, with each coral connected to many others. Some of these colonial corals have skeletons of limestone that build up to form brilliantly colored coral reefs that are home to thousands of species of marine animals.

Among the fastest growing corals on the reef, the staghorn coral can be pink, blue, or yellow

CORAL REEFS

Hard corals absorb minerals from seawater and use them to make limestone cups that support their soft bodies. When the corals die, their stony skeletons survive, and new corals grow on top of them. Over thousands of years, this builds up a vast depth of coral rock capped by many different types of living coral. These reefs form on tropical coasts and around islands, especially in the western Pacific and Indian oceans, and the Caribbean and Red seas.

► CORAL COLONIES

Colonial corals are made up of individual coral polyps (seen here in white) linked to others by tubular stolons, or branches (red). The polyps use their stinging tentacles to gather food, digest it, and share the nutrients.



► VITAL PARTNERSHIP

Clear tropical waters contain very little edible plankton. But tiny algae (see here as green specks) living in the tissues of tropical reef corals can make sugar using the energy of sunlight. The sugar allows the corals to flourish in the food-poor water. This arrangement is known as symbiosis.



Sea fans have tough but flexible spreading branches

Platelike star coral is made up of hundreds of small coral polyps

Finger coral